the one used by Vasco da Gama, would be around the Cape of Good Hope. That said, even if the Indian Ocean is closed in a geographic sense, India's interests are not confined to the Indian Ocean Region.

Sir Girija Shankar Bajpai, the first Secretary General of the MEA, used to say that India's natural interests stretched from Suez to Shanghai.[22] This was when India had just gained its independence. With economic reforms and a faster pace of economic growth, India is becoming a major trading nation once again. Its trade finds its way through the Indian Ocean to its two biggest markets, the United States and China, as well as to the ASEAN countries. In addition, India now enjoys closer relations with Japan compared to in the 20th century. Therefore, India's interests currently stretch well beyond both Suez and Shanghai. It follows that India is developing a stake in the South China Sea and beyond, just as China doing the same in the Indian Ocean.

From the Indian perspective, foreign and security policy in India's neigh-bourhood covers the entire expanse of the Asia-Pacific and extends to the Persian Gulf and West Asia (which Europeans designate as the Middle East). India straddles, and is the fulcrum of, the region between the Suez and Shanghai, between West and East Asia, and between the Mediterranean and the South China Seas. Therefore, India sees itself as part and parcel of any future security architecture in Asia, including in the vast Indo-Pacific space. Embracing the idea of the Indo-Pacific allows India to continue its established foreign and security policies, including abjuring military alliances and establishing a rule-based world order, thereby enabling India to become a partner of choice for both developing and developed countries.

The inclusion of Africa and the Persian Gulf in the Indo-Pacific has special significance for India. Many countries of the east African seaboard, Kenya, Tanzania, and South Africa included, have significant expatriate Indian-origin peoples.